The Rabbit, the Bear and the Zinniga-Zanniga

By Theo Geisel (aka Dr. Seuss)

INTRODUCTION

Br'er Rabbit, the Tortise and the Hare and even Bugs Bunny. . . Literature and cartoons are full of quick-thinking rabbits out-smarting their counterparts. One little known tale featuring a very smart rabbit comes to us from Theo Geisel, known by most everyone as Dr. Seuss: The Rabbit, the Bear and the Zinnaga-Zanniga.

Once of upon of a time, way down south,
Lived a very big bear with a very big mouth
And very big teeth in his very big jaws
And very big claws in his very big paws.

And this very big bear, who was hunting for meat,
One day spied a rabbit who looked good to eat.
"A-ha!" thought the bear. "He looks tender, all right!
Oh, boy, I'll have rabbit for supper tonight!"

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So, on his big feet, he crept up to the rabbit.
He crouched very low and leaned forward to grab it,
But, just as his jaws were 'bout ready to nab it,
The rabbit looked up and he say the bear's face.
"Oh-oh!" gulped the rabbit. "I'm in a bad place!"

And I see with a glance
That it's no use to fight, 'cause I haven't a chance
For I am a rabbit with very small jaws
And very small claws in my very small paws.

"Alas" thought the rabbit. "This moment's my last
Unless I ***think*** terribly, terribly fast . . .
I've got to be smart! Got to think of some trick!"
And that little old rabbit, the thought mighty quick.

Then, just as the teeth of the bear touched his head,
The rabbit jumped up and he suddenly said,
"One, two, three, four, five, six . . . seven . . . eight . . .
nine!
Nine . . . ? Only ***nine*** . . . ? That's a very bad sign!

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Poor bear!" sighed the rabbit, then counted again.
And this time, he counted from one up to ***ten***!

"Huh . . . ?" the bear grunted. He stared and he stopped.
He looked mighty puzzled. His jaw sort of dropped.
"Now, what were you counting, then? What did you see?
Do you mean to say something's the matter with me?"

"Err . . . well," said the rabbit, from down where he
stood.
"I sure hate to tell you. It isn't too good."
"I was counting the eyelashes 'round your two eyes,
Your left eye . . . your right eye . . . and, to my surprise,
They weren't the same number!
Almost, but not quite.
You've ***ten*** on **your** *left* eye, but ***nine*** on your ***right***!

"I'm sorry . . . SO sorry. But, sir it is true.
Poor bear! This is dreadful! One eyelash too few!"
The bear looked upset.

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He looked frightfully sad.
"Good gracious!" he gasped.
"Is ***that*** really so bad?"

"Err . . . well," said the rabbit. "I've counted the hairs
That grow on the eyelids of hundreds of bears
And I always have noticed, in adding up theirs,
That they always come out to an even amount.
But ***yours***, Mr. Bear, make and ***un***-even count!

And I guess that's the reason," the rabbit then said,
"For the lop-sided way that you're holding your head.
It's twisted! It's sagging! Because of the weight
Of your un-even lashes, you can't hold it straight!"

"My head . . . ?" groaned the bear with an unhappy roar.
"Why, I never knew it was crooked before!
But, now that you say so, it ***does*** feel quite funny!"
"I'll bet that it hurts you a lot," said the bunny.
"I'll bet that it hurts you right down to your tail!
My! My! Mr. Bear, you look horribly pale!

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"Say . . . !" How does your throat feel? A little bit
prickly?"
"It does!" moaned the bear. "And my stomach feels
tickly!
Poor me!" cried the bear. "I feel all-over sickly!"
"Tch! Tch!" said the rabbit. "It's just as I reckoned.
Your ailment is getting much worse by the second.
Your tongue, Mr. Bear . . . Does it taste a bit fuzzy?
Your brain, Mr. Bear . . . Does it feel a bit wuzzy?"

"Why, yes!" gasped the bear. "It most certainly does!
Is that a bad sign . . . all that fuzz and that wuzz?"
"It is," said the rabbit. "Alas and alack!
It's a sign that your trouble has spread to your back.
For, even right now, while I'm standing here speaking,
I hear a loud sound from your backbone! It's ***creaking***!"

"Oh, the lack of an eyelash can make you a wreck,
The lack of an eyelash can break a bear's neck!

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It can break all your ribs! It can ruin your heart!
Who knows what might happen! You ***may*** fall apart!
Be careful, poor bear! Don't you even dare cough
Or your feet and your tail and your nose may fall off!"
And he gave that big bear such a sorrowful look
That the bear started trembling. He shook and he
shook.
"Ah, me!" the bear blubbered. "Oh, what can I do?
Must I die just because of one eyelash too few?"

"Oh, HOW can I get one more eyelash to grow . . . !"
"Err, well," smiled the rabbit. "It happens I know
Of a way you ***might*** do it. You're standing, you see,
Right under a Zinniga-Zanniga Tree!"

"Now, the flowers of this tree have some wonderful
juices
That doctors have put to some marvelous uses.
Their juice, I am told, is so strong that it cures
Sicknesses even much greater than yours."

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"The juice of these flowers cures measles and mumps.
The juice of these flowers cures freckles and bumps.
Whooping cough! Croup! Also colic and sprains!
Chickenpox! Smallpox! And belly-ache pains!
There's ***nothing***, they say, that this juice cannot do.
So I think, Mr. Bear, it's the right juice for you. "

"What ***you*** ought to do, least it seems so to me,
Is climb up this Zinniga-Zanniga Tree
And pick yourself one of these wonderful flowers.
Hold it tight to your eye for a couple of hours,
And I know it'll cure you. I haven't a doubt!
For the lash you are lacking will suddenly sprout!"

"You mean," cried the bear, "I'll have ten on each eye?
You mean," cried the bear, "that I don't have to die?
Oh, thanks!" cried the bear. "You are wonderfully good."
And he climbed up that tree just as fast as he could.

And, while that big bear held the flower to his face,
The rabbit, like lightning, raced off from that place!

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And, thus, he escaped from the very big jaws
Of that very big bear with the very big claws,
And he laughed as he ran on his very small paws:
It's always the same when you fight with Big Guys...
A bit of Quick-Thinking counts much more than size!"

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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